

Module : Building a sustainable and socially responsible path

Assessing a company's impact

👉 *CAUTION : It can be challenging to accurately assess a company's real impact. Access to information is not always straightforward. We suggest combining approaches and adopting a holistic view to evaluate and reduce a company's environmental impact while contributing to overall sustainability.*

Step 1 : Select The Company You Want To Assess

The company I wish to assess is:

Step 2 : What Is The Company's Business Model And Activity?

What are this company's activities? How does it generate revenue? (e.g., what products does it sell?)

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Step 3 : Information Search

To better prepare for your analysis in the next step, we suggest a preliminary phase of information gathering. Embrace your inner Sherlock Holmes to uncover as much information as possible about this company :) ! Here are some suggestions for sources to gather maximum information:

1. Company's website : Companies committed to sustainability often display their certifications and labels on their site. Look for sections on sustainability or social responsibility. Is it a mission-driven company? Does it have the status of a social and solidarity economy enterprise? Is it a recognised public utility organisation? Is it an association?

2. Annual and sustainability reports : Many companies publish non-financial reports under the Corporate Sustainability Reporting Directive (CSRD). These reports detail their sustainability, CSR, and social impact performances with concrete evidence and actions. They are valuable resources for assessing a company's commitment and transparency. To access them, simply search "company name + non-financial report" in a search engine.

3. Rankings : Some journalistic sites offer company rankings based on different sustainability criteria, such as pollution or positive impact, as well as working conditions.

4. Certifying organizations : Independent bodies award sustainability labels, such as ISO 14001 for environmental management. Check their websites for lists of certified companies. We have included a non-exhaustive list of major European labels in the appendix of this document.

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Step 4 : Evaluating the company's impact

1. ENVIRONMENTAL AND CARBON FOOTPRINT:

Do the company's activities have, in your opinion, a rather negative or positive impact on the environment?

Company's impact on biodiversity, waste production, goods transportation, water and energy consumption, waste management, employee commuting, supply chain analysis, evaluating suppliers' environmental impact, use of natural resources, etc.

Very negative Neutral Very authentic
-5 -4 -3 -2 -1 0 1 2 3 4 5

2. HUMAN AND SOCIAL BALANCE:

Do the company's activities have, in your opinion, a rather negative or positive impact on societal issues?

Eliminating poverty in all its forms, eradicating hunger and improving nutrition, ensuring healthy lives for all ages, ensuring access to quality education for all, promoting gender equality, reducing inequalities within and among countries, fostering peaceful and inclusive societies for sustainable development, internal employee treatment, how the company manages workers' rights, diversity, pay equity, health and safety of employees, and its contributions to local communities. Does the company support local communities through volunteering, donations, and partnerships, etc.?

Very negative Neutral Very authentic
-5 -4 -3 -2 -1 0 1 2 3 4 5

3. STATUS, LABELS, CERTIFICATIONS, AND RANKINGS

Based on the company's, labels, certifications, or rankings, would you say the public opinion of this company is more positive or negative?

History of scandals related to the company's activities, mission-driven company, recognised public utility, status as part of the social and solidarity economy, testimonials on Glassdoor, inclusion in rankings, etc.

Very negative Neutral Very authentic
-5 -4 -3 -2 -1 0 1 2 3 4 5

4. AUTHENTICITY

Based on your analysis, do you think the image the company tries to project is consistent with its actual actions? Do you think this company is engaged in Greenwashing or social washing?

Highlighting aspects that ultimately have little positive impact to appear more ecological or impactful, transformation ambitions never followed by actions, vague or unsubstantiated claims, misleading use of ecological logos or symbols, deliberately ignoring negative environmental or social impacts to falsely appear positive, lack of transparency reports, promotion of misleading "green" products, etc.

Very negative Neutral Very authentic
-5 -4 -3 -2 -1 0 1 2 3 4 5

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Step 5 : Synthesis

In the light of the information you have just gathered, do you think that the company you have just evaluated is the right fit for you? Why or why not?

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ANNEX 1: Certifications and labels

To assess a company's commitment to sustainability, looking at the certifications and labels is useful. Here are some of the most significant ones for sustainable development:



ISO 14001 (Environmental Management System) : An international standard certifying that a company has implemented an effective environmental management system.



Fair Trade : A label guaranteeing that products such as coffee, cocoa, tea, and clothing are produced fairly, ensuring fair wages and decent working conditions..



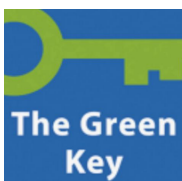
EU Ecolabel : The European Union's label indicating that products meet strict energy efficiency, environmental impact, and health criteria.



EMAS (Eco-Management and Audit Scheme): The EU's voluntary environmental management instrument, which companies and other organisations can use to evaluate, report, and improve their environmental performance.



Le Label B corp : Certification internationale pour les entreprises démontrant un engagement envers des pratiques commerciales durables, la responsabilité sociale d'entreprise et la transparence.



The green key : An eco-label for tourism and leisure establishments and is awarded to establishments that fulfil a list of environmental and social requirements.



Energy star: While originated in the USA, Energy Star certification is used in the EU for marking energy-efficient products and buildings.

Remember, the relevance and application of these certifications can vary by industry, and companies may hold multiple certifications to cover different aspects of their environmental and societal impact.